MANTIS BUSINESS PLAN

The Future of Sustainable Protein

MANTIS

Group 44	Assignment 4	April 2026
New Enterprise Development	BAA1003	Dr. Eric Clinton

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Executive Summary

Purpose of Plan

This business plan has been prepared by the five founding members of Mantis to support a funding application to Enterprise Ireland under the High Potential Start-Up (HPSU) programme and to present investment opportunity to potential investors. Mantis is seeking €100,000 in investment in exchange for a 5% equity stake, in addition to the €30,000 Enterprise Ireland HPSU grant already approved, giving total start-up capital of €130,000.

Product and Its Advantages

Mantis is a 500ml ready-to-drink chocolate protein shake made with Irish UHT milk, cricket powder, and buffalo worm powder. The product delivers 60 grams of protein per bottle (12 grams per 100ml), making it the highest-protein-density ready-to-drink shake currently available in the Irish market. Competitors, including Avonmore, GetPro, Huel RTD, and MyProtein, range from 6 to 9 grams of protein per 100ml.

Both insect species used in Mantis are fully authorised under EU Novel Food regulations, crickets from February 2022 and buffalo worms from January 2023. The product is shelf-stable under UHT processing, requiring no refrigeration until opened, and retails at €4.00 per bottle with a wholesale price of €2.67.

Market Opportunity

The global protein supplement market is valued at approximately €20 billion and is growing at 8 to 10 per cent per annum. The Irish health food and sports nutrition market has seen consistent double-digit growth, driven by increasing health consciousness among 18 to 35-year-olds, the rise of gym culture, and growing awareness of sustainable nutrition. No insect protein RTD drink currently

exists in the Irish market, creating a first-mover opportunity for Mantis in a category already established in key European markets, including the Netherlands, Germany, and Belgium.

Mantis will distribute exclusively through physical retail channels in Year 1, targeting Holland & Barrett (14 Irish stores), Nourish Health Stores (20 stores), and independent gyms and fitness studios nationwide, placing the product on over 780 shelves across the country. From Year 3, the plan includes expansion into national grocery stores, including Tesco Ireland and Dunnes Stores.

Management Team

Mantis is founded and operated by five DCU New Enterprise Development students, each taking responsibility for a core business function:

- Ben - Chief Executive Officer, product development lead
- Cathal - Chief Operating Officer, supply chain and manufacturing
- Robyn - Chief Marketing Officer, brand and consumer strategy
- James - Chief Commercial Officer, financial projections and investor relations
- Ella - Chief Financial Officer, sales, retail partnerships, and investment pitch

The team completed 27 recipe iterations over the development phase and conducted blind taste testing with a panel of 26 people, receiving consistently positive feedback. The formulation has been developed to ensure EU Novel Food compliance from day one, with full HACCP planning in place.

Financial Projections Summary

	Year 1 (2027)	Year 2 (2028)	Year 3 (2029)
Sales Revenue	€93,454	€542,558	€2,436,056
Exports	–	–	–
Net Profit / (Loss)	(€23,752)	€73,244	€562,448
Investment	€130,000	€130,000	€130,000
Employment (FTEs)	5	5	5

Mantis is projected to break even operationally in Year 2 and to reach a net profit of €562,448 with revenue of €2,436,056 by Year 3. The gross profit margin expands from 34.6% in Year 1 to 40.9% in Year 3 as per-unit production costs fall with scale. The closing cash balance remains positive in all three years, including under a 30% revenue downside scenario.

Financial Projections

Mantis is seeking a total of €230,000 in start-up capital: €100,000 from the five founding members (equity), €30,000 from Enterprise Ireland (HPSU grant, approved), and €100,000 from investment partners in exchange for a 5% equity stake after year 3, valuing Mantis at €2,000,000. The investment will be deployed as follows: 80% (€80,000) toward localising buffalo worm production on a half-acre site in County Meath, and 20% (€20,000) toward research and development of Irish-grown oat milk for use in a future product variant. Full funding requirements are set out in Section 10.

Company Description

Promoters and Shareholders

Mantis is a pre-revenue startup incorporated in the Republic of Ireland. The company is owned equally by five founding promoters, each holding 20 shares at €1 nominal value, with a combined share premium of €99,900 representing the founder capital investment. The shareholders, their roles, and their financial contributions are set out below.

Name	Role	Shares	% Holding	Cash Invested
Ben	CEO / Product	20	20%	€20,000
Cathal	COO / Operations	20	20%	€20,000
Robyn	CMO / Marketing	20	20%	€20,000
James	CCO / Finance	20	20%	€20,000
Ella	CFO / Investor Relations	20	20%	€20,000
Total		**100**	**100%**	**€100,000**

All five founders are actively involved in the day-to-day operations of the business. Two founders are directly allocated to production activities (their time costs are captured within cost of goods sold), and three carry out business development, marketing, and administrative functions. In Years 1 and 2, each founder receives a salary of €7,200 per annum, reflecting the bootstrapped nature of the early-stage business. By Year 3, salaries will be aligned to a market rate of €35,000 per annum as the company reaches a scale that supports realistic compensation.

Advisors

Mantis operates with the following professional advisors:

Accountant / Financial Advisor	External accountancy practice retained at €200 per month for bookkeeping, payroll, and tax compliance. Name and contact to be finalised prior to trading.
Legal Advisor	External legal firm retained at €125 per month for HACCP documentation, Novel Food regulatory compliance, and contract review. Name and contact to be finalised prior to trading.
Enterprise Ireland Advisor	HPSU development advisor assigned through Enterprise Ireland. Contact details available on request.
Manufacturing Partner	Four Acre Foods, Enniscorthy, Co. Wexford - contract manufacturing partner providing blending, UHT processing, and packaging services.
Ingredient Supplier	SnackInsects, Netherlands - EU-certified supplier of cricket powder and buffalo worm powder to Novel Food specification.

Products and Services

Background to Development

Mantis was conceived in response to the growing global protein demand and the structural unsustainability of conventional whey protein production. The founding team identified a regulatory window created by the EU's authorisation of cricket powder (February 2022) and buffalo worm powder (January 2023) as Novel Foods, which for the first time made insect protein legally viable as a food ingredient across all 27 EU member states without requiring an individual company application.

The product was developed through 27 recipe iterations over the feasibility study period, refining the ratio of Irish UHT milk, cricket powder, buffalo worm powder, cocoa, rapeseed oil, xanthan gum, and sucralose to achieve a palatable chocolate flavour that fully masks any insect taste. A blind taste test conducted with 26 participants produced consistently positive results.

Benefits and Features

- 60 grams of protein per 500ml bottle - 12g per 100ml, more than any comparable RTD product on the Irish market
- Dual insect protein sources (cricket + buffalo worm) providing a complete amino acid profile
- UHT shelf-stable - no refrigeration required, enabling ambient distribution and standard retail shelf placement
- Chocolate flavour using natural cocoa - familiar and approachable for first-time insect protein consumers

- EU Novel Food authorised ingredients - full regulatory compliance from day one
- Made with Irish UHT whole milk, supporting local dairy supply chain

Unique Selling Points

- First insect protein RTD drink in the Irish market - genuine category creation rather than product imitation
- Highest protein density of any RTD protein shake on Irish retail shelves
- Environmental narrative: 6.5 times less CO_2 per kg of protein than whey, 80% less methane than cattle
- Competitive pricing: at €4.00 retail, Mantis sits within the premium protein drink range (GetPro €3.50-€4.50) while delivering superior protein content

Advantages to customers

- Consumers receive more protein per serving than from any comparable product at a comparable price point
- Purchasing Mantis allows environmentally conscious consumers to align their nutrition choices with their sustainability values without compromising on performance
- The RTD format offers convenience - no mixing, measuring, or refrigeration required

Disadvantages and Weak Point

- Consumer acceptance of insect-based food is not yet mainstream in Ireland, requiring education and normalisation at point of sale
- Mantis cannot claim a vegetarian or vegan label as insects are classified as animals under EU food law
- The product is not suitable for consumers with crustacean or dust mite allergies, limiting the total addressable market

Future Developments

- Irish buffalo worm production hub: A planned half acre facility in Country Meath, using climate controlled containers to produce buffalo worms domestically, eliminating import dependency and significantly reducing ingredient cost from Year 3
- Irish oat milk variant: research into producing an oat milk base using Irish-grown oats, creating a circular economy where oats feed the worms and oat milk replaces the dairy base in a future dairy-free variant
- Flavour extension: vanilla and berry variants planned for Year 2 pending Year 1 sales validation
- Grocery multiples entry: Tesco Ireland and Dunnes Stores targeted for Year 3 national listings

Long-Term Aim of the Business

Mantis aims to become the leading insect protein food brand in Ireland and, within five years, to establish a presence in at least three additional European markets where insect protein consumer adoption is most advanced - specifically the Netherlands, Belgium, and Germany. The long-term vision is for Mantis to own its full supply chain from worm cultivation to finished product, building a vertically integrated, low-carbon protein business that can demonstrate to the Irish food industry that sustainable nutrition is commercially viable at scale.

The preferred exit strategy for investors is a trade sale within five to seven years to a larger food or beverage group - Glanbia, Kerry Group, or Arla are considered the most natural acquirers given their existing protein category presence and sustainability commitments. We are building Mantis to be bought, not just to be run.

Objectives

The following milestones have been identified for the first five years of operation:

Year 1 (2027)	Achieve 35,045 unit sales across Holland & Barrett, Nourish, and 780 gym/health store locations nationwide. Establish brand recognition in the Irish health and wellness segment. Complete HACCP registration and Novel Food labelling compliance. Maintain positive cash balance.
Year 2 (2028)	Scale to 203,459 units across full 780-shelf distribution footprint. Achieve operating break-even. Launch second flavour variant. Begin feasibility assessment for County Meath buffalo worm production hub.
Year 3 (2029)	Achieve 913,521 units and €2.4M revenue. Secure first national grocery multiple listing (Tesco or Dunnes). Complete buffalo worm production hub construction. Begin Irish oat milk R&D. Net profit of €562,448.
Year 4 (2030)	Launch dairy-free oat milk variant. Enter first export market (Netherlands or Belgium). Reach 2M+ units annually. Begin trade sale process or Series A fundraising.

Year 5 (2031)	Establish Mantis as the leading insect protein brand in Ireland with international distribution in 2+ EU markets. Target trade sale or significant secondary investment.

PESTLE Analysis

Political

- EU regulatory approval for insect protein (crickets 2022, buffalo worms 2023) supports market entry.
- Ireland's sustainability and circular economy policies align with MANTIS's low-emission narrative.
- Potential government incentives for local production and green innovation (County Meath hub).

Economic

- Competitive retail pricing (€4.00) positions MANTIS within the premium protein drink range.
- Low unit cost (€1.75 Y1 → €1.57 Y3) enhances profitability as scale increases.
- Global insect protein market growing at ~30% CAGR, offering strong export potential.
- Risk of larger FMCG players entering the category once validated.

Social

- Cultural resistance to insect-based foods remains a barrier; education and sampling required.
- Rising consumer interest in sustainability and high-protein diets supports adoption.
- Early adopters likely to be fitness enthusiasts and eco-conscious consumers

Technological

- UHT shelf-stable format eliminates cold-chain dependency, reducing logistics costs.
- Opportunity to integrate Irish oat milk R&D for circular supply chain innovation.
- Potential for automation and localised insect farming technology to scale production.

Legal

- Compliance with EU food safety and allergen regulations (crustacean-related risks).
- Contract manufacturing agreements limit production control but ensure regulatory consistency.
- Intellectual property protection for recipe and branding strengthens market position.

Environmental

- 6.5× less CO_2 per kg of protein than whey; 80% less methane than cattle.
- Circular economy model: oats feed worms, oat milk used in drink.
- Supports Ireland's climate targets and sustainable food innovation agenda

Market Analysis

Category definition & market context

Mantis competes in the ready-to-drink (RTD) protein beverage segment (functional beverage / sports nutrition crossover). RTD protein is expanding globally as consumers prioritise convenience + functional nutrition, with growth supported by increased gym participation, on-the-go lifestyles, and D2C purchasing behaviour.

At a global level, multiple market trackers size the RTD protein beverage category at approximately USD 1.9B (2024), growing to USD 3.6B by 2033 (7.5% CAGR). Other estimates land in a similar range (e.g., USD 1.73B in 2024 → USD 3.49B by 2033; 8.1% CAGR).

Ireland context. RTD protein beverages are a fast-growing niche inside the Irish functional drinks and sports nutrition space. One Ireland-specific industry report cites 14.3% CAGR (2020–2024) for RTD protein beverage imports, indicating rapid category formation and increasing consumer trial.

Target market (segmentation, persona logic & purchase drivers)

Primary research (n=157 survey responses) indicates strongest demand from consumers seeking performance outcomes (protein density, recovery), but secondary research shows the broader RTD segment is increasingly pulled by convenience and “everyday wellness”, not only bodybuilding.

Mantis’ core customer groups (Ireland, launch phase):

Health & fitness enthusiasts (core volume)	Motivations: recovery, muscle building, high-protein lifestyle, macro tracking. Purchase drivers: protein per bottle, taste, price-to-protein value, availability in gyms/convenience.
Eco-conscious consumers (brand advocacy segment)	Motivations: lower-impact protein alternatives; values-led purchasing. Purchase drivers: credible sustainability claims + proof (quantified impact), packaging and ingredient transparency.
Students & young professionals (growth segment)	Motivations: portable nutrition that fits busy schedules. Purchase drivers: price accessibility, multipacks/subscriptions, taste, social proof (influencers/peer trial).

Busy workers / commuters / frequent travellers (occasion-based)	Motivations: “grab-and-go” nutrition between work and training. Purchase drivers: shelf stability, convenience retail access, low-mess packaging.
Early adopters (innovation segment)	Motivations: novelty, “future of food”, trend adoption. Purchase drivers: storytelling, PR coverage, limited drops, trial/sampling.

Across segments, taste and functional value remain decisive: the category is crowded, so a novel protein source must still win on flavour, texture, and outcomes.

TAM / SAM / SOM

Because robust, publicly accessible Irish revenue figures for “RTD protein drinks” can be difficult to source without paid datasets, Mantis should present sizing in a defensible way:

TAM	Irish consumers purchasing protein beverages/shakes (RTD + powders) for performance or lifestyle wellness
SAM	Consumers aged ~18–40 with active lifestyle and/or wellness focus, reachable through gyms, campuses, and D2C.
SOM	Early adopters + gym members + students in Dublin-first launch area reachable through sampling, gym fridges, and campus activations in Year 1

Market trends shaping demand

Convenience-driven nutrition is the core growth engine	RTD formats continue to grow because they remove preparation time and fit busy routines
RTD products are moving from “sports niche” to “everyday wellness”	Category reports increasingly describe RTD shakes as mainstream convenience/wellness products, not only post-workout supplements
Sustainable packaging expectations are rising	Market commentary highlights retailer pressure for more sustainable formats and shifts away from plastics

Price sensitivity remains a barrier	RTD shakes are commonly described as more expensive than homemade/powder alternatives—so value communication (protein per euro, convenience premium) is essential.

Competitive set & whitespace

Direct competitive set (Ireland)

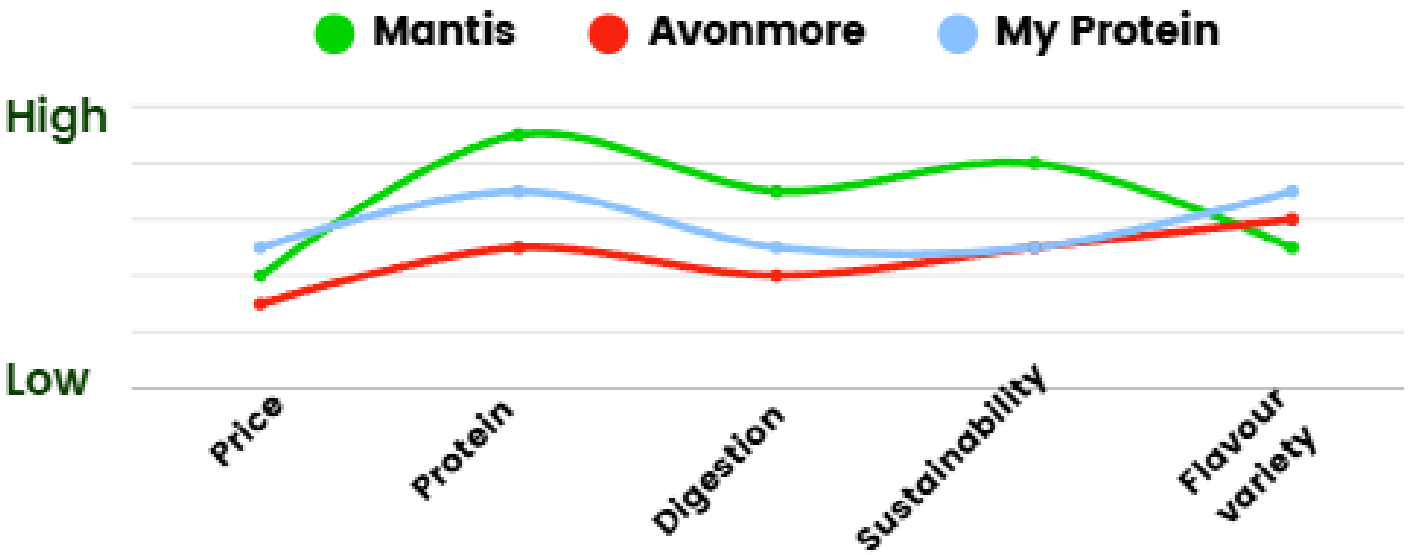
Mantis competes against established dairy-based RTD protein shakes (e.g., mainstream protein milks and sports RTDs) and plant-based RTD shakes (positioned on "clean" and sustainability).

Indirect competitive set

- Protein powders (better € / gram protein, but low convenience)
- Protein bars (portable, but different consumption occasions)
- Meal replacement RTDs (overlap for convenience seekers)

Competitive whitespace

Mantis' whitespace is "performance-first sustainable protein": a product framed primarily as a high-performance RTD shake (taste + recovery), with sustainability as a verified "second win", rather than leading with the insect origin.



Competitor Analysis

Brand	Product	Protein Source	Protein G/100ml	Price / 100ml
Mantis	RTD Chocolate Shake	Insects – crickets, buffalo worms	12g	€0.80
Avonmore	Protein Milks	Dairy	5.4g	€0.40
Getpro	Protein Yogurt Drinks	Dairy	8g	€0.93
My Protein	Impact RTD shakes	Dairy/ Plant	7.6g	€0.90

Marketing & sales strategy

Go-to-market approach (phased)

Phase 1: Trial and normalisation (Year 1)	Objective: maximise trial and build “taste-first” credibility. The main focus in Year 1 is getting people to try the product and showing that it tastes good. Because insect protein is still new to most consumers, building “taste-first” credibility is key. This will be done through sampling in gyms, university campuses, and events such as WellFest, where there is a strong fit with the target market. These environments are more likely to convert into actual purchases as people are already interested in fitness and protein products. To reduce bias around insect protein, Mantis will use blind taste testing at events, allowing consumers to try the product without knowing the protein source initially, before revealing it afterwards. Marketing will focus on performance and protein quality first, rather than leading with the insect aspect, helping reduce initial resistance. Social media will also play a role, particularly through micro-influencers in fitness and student lifestyle. The focus will be on more natural, user-generated style content rather than overly polished ads, as this builds trust. To reduce any hesitation at the point of purchase, QR codes will be placed on packaging. These will link to simple information about the product, including where the protein comes from and the sustainability benefits, without overcomplicating it.
Phase 2: Repeat purchase and channel expansion (Year 2)	In year 2 the focus shifts from trial to repeat purchase and making Mantis easier to access for consumers. Mantis will expand its presence in gyms, fitness studios, and premium convenience locations where consumers are already buying similar products. Mantis will also explore B2B opportunities such as supplying gyms, sports teams, and corporate wellness programmes in bulk.The aim is to make it part of a regular routine rather than a once-off purchase. Multipacks and subscriptions will be introduced to encourage repeat purchases and reduce the effort it takes customers to reorder. Partnerships with universities and corporate wellness programmes will also be targeted to increase visibility and volume. Email and SMS reminders will be used to encourage repeat purchase, particularly for customers who initially purchase through sampling campaigns
Phase 3: Scale (Year 3+)	Objective: grow distribution and defend share.. From Year 3 onwards, the focus is on scaling the business in a controlled way. Distribution will expand further into retail, but only where it makes sense financially and where demand has already been proven. Product expansion, such as new flavours or formats, will be based on actual sales data rather than assumptions. Limited batch flavour drops may be introduced to create urgency and test demand before committing to full product expansion.

Route to Market

Direct-to-consumer (D2C)
Role: higher margin, data capture, subscription, brand community. Subscription reminders to reduce churn

Gyms & fitness studios
Role: high-fit consumption occasion; trial + impulse purchase. Branded fridge placement to increase visibility at point of purchase.

Universities & events
Role: early adopter density and repeatable sampling windows. Blind taste testing to reduce bias around insect protein.

Retail (phased)
- Start with health-focused outlets and premium convenience; evaluate supermarket entry once velocity is proven. Focus on high-protein / health aisles for better product fit.

Pricing strategy

Our pricing works to balance protein-per-euro value, the convenience premium of RTD, and buyer price sensitivity (RTD is widely described as pricier than powders/homemade).

Our structure:

- Single bottle price positioned vs. premium RTD competitors
- Multipacks, bundle pricing to increase average order value
- Subscription (best value, reduces reorder friction)

Sales strategy

Year 1 priorities:

Lock in 20–50 high-fit “trial fridges” (gyms + studios) with weekly restock cadence.

Run structured sampling (convert to D2C via QR discount; capture emails).

Build 2–3 anchor partnerships (e.g., university gym + one festival/event + one sports club network).

Track conversion rate from sampling to purchase.

Year 2 priorities:

Increase points of distribution (POD) and focus on sales velocity per POD.

Negotiate retail placement based on proven velocity and repeat rate.

Sustainability will act as a supporting factor in purchase decisions, rather than the main selling point, reinforcing the product rather than leading it.

Focus on repeat purchase rate as a key success metric.

Advertising & promotion

Brand positioning statement

"Mantis is a high-performance RTD protein drink that delivers convenient recovery and strength, powered by a next-generation, lower-impact protein."

This is our main consumer messaging, aimed to encourage customers to purchase Mantis due to our convenience and nutrition.

Positioning logic:

- Lead with performance + taste (reduces novelty risk)
- Support with verified sustainability proof (creates differentiation and PR value)

Messaging pillars

At Mantis our key marketing pillars are to educate, normalise and build trust between consumers and our product. We will do this by driving 4 key messages:

1. **Performance:** protein delivery, recovery, strength
2. **Convenience:** "grab-and-go" nutrition (aligned with RTD category growth drivers)
3. **Sustainability:** quantified impact, packaging choices, transparent sourcing
4. **Taste-first:** flavour and texture proof through sampling content

Campaigns

Over years 1 and 2 mantis will focus on education, normalisation and trust building through 4 key campaigns

Gym takeover weeks (trial engine)	Mantis will collaborate with relevant and trending class based gym such as Barry's Bootcamp and Saint Studios to host takeovers. At these events we will be able to educate our target market on the benefits of Mantis, build trust by locating ourselves in their familiar environment and promote normalisation by handing out samples.

Campus activations (early adopter density)	Mantis will do “pop-ups” at universitys across Ireland. This gives us the opportunity to target “early-adopters” and “bust commuters”, while using the opportunity to educate students on our product.
Event partnerships (visibility + press)	Sports events and festivals where functional beverages are already accepted. Through pop ups at festivals such as WellFest, Mantis once again lands in the home of our target market. Giving us the opportunity to educate and provide samples to more openminded health and fitness enthusiasts.
Retail launch support (when ready)	POS education + QR-led explainers + “taste challenge” sampling. This will be where Mantis really embeds the trust and normalisation pillars. By appearing in familiar and regular environments of our consumers we become more trust worthy and less of a “novelty”.

KPI framework

To measure the effectiveness of our campaigns we will look at:

Awareness	Reach and share of voice in Dublin fitness/student segments PR mentions and sentiment
Trial & conversion	Sampling volume → scan rate → first purchase conversion Conversion by channel (gym vs campus vs events)
Retention	30/60/90-day repeat rate (D2C) Subscription conversion rate and churn
Commercial performance	Sales velocity per point of distribution Gross margin by channel
Brand health	Taste” rating from post-purchase surveys Consumer acceptance (perceived normality) vs. novelty concerns

Research and Development

Initial Research and Development of Mantis

The research and development phase for Mantis was a rigorous, science-led process focused on overcoming the stigma surrounding insects through culinary excellence and technical precision. To achieve a premium sensory profile, we collaborated with a culinary science student who conducted 27 recipe iterations, meticulously refining the balance between nutrition and taste. This process culminated in a blind taste test with a panel of 26 participants, where the final formulation achieved an impressive 54% top-tier rating of 5/5. As shown in our previous Technical Feasibility study, these trials were essential for identifying cocoa powder as the most effective flavour mask to neutralise the earthy notes of the insect protein.

The final chocolate flavoured recipe, detailed in our Product Overview, leverages a high-protein blend of dehydrated crickets and buffalo worms (30g each) combined with UHT whole milk for a smooth, familiar mouthfeel. To ensure shelf stability and consumer appeal, we integrated xanthan gum for texture and sucralose for sweetness without the caloric load of sugar. Our primary survey of 157 respondents confirms that this R&D focus on taste and protein content aligns perfectly with Irish consumer demands. By validating the product's microbial safety and low moisture content (5.9%), we have moved from a lab concept to a technically viable, market-ready beverage that bridges the gap between high-performance nutrition and environmental sustainability.

Research and Development post Dragon’s Investment

To further the evolution of Mantis, we are allocating the €20,000 investment to pioneer the localised production of oat milk in Ireland. Currently, Ireland imports the vast majority of its oat milk internationally, despite being a world-class producer of raw oats. Our goal is to develop a domestic production process that utilises oat milk as a sustainable substitute for UHT whole milk. Crucially, our research will focus on a whole grain extraction method. Many commercial oat milks are produced by stripping away the bran and germ, leaving behind mostly starch and sugar; according to nutritional research, this process can remove up to 17 essential nutrients and significantly reduce fiber content. Oat milk creates a creamier, more nutritious base that complements our insect protein blend without the need for excessive synthetic additives. By

retaining the nutrient dense parts of the grain, we ensure Mantis remains a functional, high-performance beverage. (Northwestern Medicine, 2021).

Through our collaboration with Enterprise Ireland and the New Frontiers programme, we will gain vital access to third-level R&D facilities and specialist food scientists to perfect this formulation. This research is a cornerstone of our growth strategy; by verticalising our supply chain and reducing reliance on international imports, we not only lower our carbon footprint but also solidify Mantis as a truly Irish innovation. Investing in this R&D allows us to lead the market in transparency and nutrition, transforming a standard dairy alternative into a premium, bioavailable fuel for the eco-conscious athlete. (Enterprise Ireland, 2014).

Product Development

The product development of Mantis was a rigorous journey of scientific refinement, as illustrated by our Technical Feasibility Study. We didn't just settle on a flavor; we conducted 27 recipe iterations to perfect the synergy between high-performance nutrition and palatable taste. As seen in our survey results, we benchmarked our progress through blind taste tests with 26 participants, where our final formulation achieved a 54% top-tier satisfaction rating. Getting the ingredients correct was a balancing act of functionality and sensory appeal. By combining 30g of dehydrated crickets and buffalo worms with a chocolate profile enhanced by cocoa powder and sucralose, we successfully neutralised the earthy notes typically associated with entomophagy (eating insects).

This precision is vital for our sustainability mission. By making insect protein indistinguishable in taste from traditional shakes, we lower the barrier for consumers to switch to a protein source that requires a fraction of the land, water, and feed compared to whey or beef. Beyond eco-friendliness, the health benefits are a core pillar of Mantis; our drink provides a bioavailable, complete protein profile, meaning it contains all nine essential amino acids, while remaining low in moisture and microbiologically safe. This R&D ensures that Mantis isn't just a green novelty, but a legitimate, nutrient-dense tool for the health-conscious consumer.

Staffing and Operations

Management and Organisation Structure

Ben Quilligan

CEO

Cathal Walsh

COO

Robyn Heavey

CMO

James Smyth

CCO

Ella Gear

CFO

The Mantis management team is made up of five members, each responsible for a key area of the business. This ensures all main functions are covered while keeping decision-making clear.

Ben acts as CEO and is responsible for the overall direction of the business and making sure the team stays aligned with the long-term vision. Robyn is the CMO and leads all marketing activity, including branding, campaigns, and customer engagement. Cathal operates as COO

and is responsible for the day-to-day running of the business, particularly the supply chain, production flow, and how the product moves from manufacturing to the customer. Ella is the CFO and manages financial planning, pricing, and overall financial performance. James is the CCO and focuses on customer insights and commercial decisions, using research and data to guide strategy.

This structure allows each member to take ownership of their area while still working closely together, which is important in the early stages. Production is fully outsourced to Four Acre Foods, so there is no need to hire staff for manufacturing. External support will also be used where needed, particularly in areas such as food safety, legal requirements, and product development.

Training Plans

As Mantis operates in the food and beverage industry, it is important that the team has a basic understanding of food safety, operations, and customer interaction from the start.

The main area of training will be food safety awareness, particularly HACCP principles. Even though production is outsourced, it is still important that the team understands how food is handled, the risks involved, and how these are controlled. This helps when working with manufacturing partners.

Training will also focus on customer service, as the business will initially operate on a direct-to-consumer basis. This includes handling orders, responding to customer queries, and maintaining a consistent level of communication.

In addition, the team will continue to develop marketing and digital skills, particularly in areas such as social media, campaign management, and content creation, as these are key to building brand awareness.

From an operations point of view, there will also be a focus on understanding supply chain and logistics, including how products move from production to the customer, managing stock, and working with delivery partners such as An Post.

Rather than formal training programmes, the focus will be on learning through experience and using external support where needed. This keeps the business flexible while still making sure the team has the right knowledge to run it properly.

Operations

The operations of Mantis are kept simple and practical from the beginning.

The main ingredient, insect protein, is sourced from SnackInsects in Germany in powdered form, which makes it easy to use in production and avoids the need for any extra processing. The rest of the ingredients, including milk, cocoa powder, stabilisers, and sweeteners, are sourced by Four Acre Foods through their existing suppliers.

Production is outsourced to Four Acre Foods. At their facility, the ingredients are mixed, heat-treated, and packaged into the final product. This means Mantis does not need to invest in its own equipment and can rely on an experienced manufacturer. Four Acre Foods specialise in protein beverages and also work regularly with startup businesses, which makes them a suitable partner.

Once the product is finished, it is sent to a StorageWorld warehouse, where stock is stored and orders are managed. Orders are then delivered using An Post Commerce. This allows Mantis to distribute products across Ireland without having to manage its own delivery system. An Post has invested in more sustainable delivery methods, including electric vehicles and carbon reduction initiatives, which supports the overall sustainability side of the brand.

This setup keeps costs low and makes the business easier to manage. It also supports the sustainability focus of Mantis, as insect protein has a lower environmental impact than traditional protein sources, and using existing partners for production and delivery reduces unnecessary waste in the supply chain.

Financial Projections

Income Sources

Mantis generates revenue from a single product, a 500ml ready-to-drink chocolate insect protein shake sold exclusively through wholesale to retail partners. The wholesale price is fixed at €2.67 per unit across all three projection years, producing a retail shelf price of €4.00 after a standard 50% retail markup. A one off Enterprise Ireland HPSU grant of €30,000 is recognised as income in Year 1 only.

Sales Volume and Revenue Growth

Year 1 sales of 35,045 units begin at 1,035 units in January 2027 and grow at 17.5% per month as brand awareness builds across Holland & Barrett, Nourish, and gym channels nationwide. Growth moderates to 15% per month in Year 2 as the business moves from launch mode into a period of consolidation and retail expansion, targeting 203,459 units. By Year 3, a sustained monthly growth rate of 12.5% drives volume to 913,521 units, reflecting Mantis establishing itself as a recognised brand within the Irish health and wellness market.

Employees and Salaries

Mantis is operated by five founders throughout Years 1 and 2. Each founder receives a salary of €600 per month (€7,200 per annum), reflecting the bootstrapped nature of the business in its early stage. In Year 3, all five salaries are aligned to a market rate of €35,000 per annum to reflect the business reaching a scale at which realistic compensation is required for future valuation purposes. Employer PRSI is applied at 11.25% on all salaries in line with Irish Revenue guidelines.

Cost of Goods Sold

The cost of goods sold reflects the early stage per-unit production cost of €1.75, comprising ingredients at €1.25, direct production and labour costs through Four Acre Foods of €0.275 and €0.225 respectively. This unit cost falls to €1.66 in Year 2 and €1.57 in Year 3 as volume purchasing from SnackInsects delivers a 5% ingredient cost saving and direct labour becomes more efficient at scale.

Equipment and Depreciation

Capital equipment expenditure in Year 1 is nil as Mantis operates under a contract manufacturing agreement with Four Acre Foods. Website development costs of €5,000 are capitalised and amortised on a straight-line basis at 20% per annum (€1,000 per year), giving a monthly charge of €83.33. No other fixed assets are acquired in the projection period.

Research and Development

R&D is budgeted at €400 per month (€4,800 per annum) in Years 1, covering ongoing recipe refinement, flavour development, and ingredient testing. This reflects the 27 iterations already completed during the feasibility stage and the continued pipeline of flavour variants being considered. A 2.5% annual inflation uplift is applied in Years 2 and 3.

Rent and Storage

Mantis uses a StorageWorld ambient storage unit in Dublin at €400 per month (€4,800 per annum). As a UHT shelf-stable product, no refrigerated storage is required. Electricity and gas are estimated at 20% of the storage rent, giving €80 per month. A 2.5% annual cost inflation uplift is applied from Year 2.

Debtor Days and Creditor Days

30% of invoiced revenue is collected in the month of sale and the remaining 70% is collected in the following month. This reflects the typical payment terms offered to retail accounts. This creates a modest accounts receivable balance at each year end. No credit terms are assumed on the purchase side, supplier invoices from SnackInsects and Four Acre Foods are assumed to be settled within the same month.

Other Key Operating Expenses

Advertising and marketing is budgeted at €2,000 per month (€24,000 in Year 1), covering digital advertising, social media campaigns, and influencer partnerships in the health and wellness segment. Marketing spend grows at a higher rate in Years 2 and 3 to support the retail expansion phase. Accounting fees are €200 per month covering bookkeeping, payroll, and tax compliance. Professional and legal fees of €125 per month cover ongoing HACCP compliance and Novel Food regulatory obligations. Transport and courier costs of €250 per month reflect An Post Commerce distribution from the StorageWorld unit to retail partners. Business registration (€50) and product liability insurance (€1,500) are one off Year 1 costs paid in

January. A general sundry allowance of €66 per month (€792 per annum) covers minor incidental expenses.

Corporation Tax

The Irish corporation tax rate of 12.5% is applied to taxable profits only. No tax is payable in Year 1 as it produces operating losses. Corporation tax becomes payable from Year 2 when the business moves into profitability.

Starting Capital

The business commences with €100,000 of founder equity, giving total opening capital of €100,000. A €30,000 Enterprise Ireland HPSU grant supports year 1 cashflow. No bank debt or external loans are assumed in the projection period, as the production process is outsourced keeping equipment expenditure to a minimum.

	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Mantis Unit Cost	€1.75	€1.66	€1.57
Mantis Price per Unit	€2.67	€2.67	€2.67
Mantis Profit per Unit	€0.92	€1.01	€1.09
Retail Markup %	50%	50%	50%
Retail Margin/ Profit	€1.33	€1.33	€1.33
Retail Selling Price	€4	€4	€4
Unit Sold	34,045	203,459	913,521
Sales Revenue	€93,454	€542,558	€2,436,056
COGS	€61,154	€337,285	€1,428,670
Gross Profit	€32,000	€205,274	€997,386
Net Profit	(€23,752)	€73,244	€562,448
Gross Profit Margin %	35%	38%	41%
Net Profit Margin %	-19%	13%	23%
Cash Balance	€60,861	€96,031	€539,894

MANTIS – PROFIT AND LOSS FORECAST

	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec	Year 1 Total	Year 2 Total	Year 3 Total
SALES															
Units Sold	1,035	1,216	1,429	1,679	1,973	2,318	2,724	3,200	3,760	4,419	5,192	6,100	35,045	203,459	913,521
Sales Revenue (€)	**€2,760**	**€3,243**	**€3,811**	**€4,477**	**€5,261**	**€6,182**	**€7,263**	**€8,534**	**€10,028**	**€11,783**	**€13,845**	**€16,268**	**€93,454**	**€542,558**	**€2,436,056**
Cost of Goods Sold (COGS)	€1,806	€2,122	€2,494	€2,930	€3,443	€4,045	€4,753	€5,585	€6,562	€7,710	€9,060	€10,645	€61,154	€337,285	€1,438,670
Gross Profit	**€954**	**€1,121**	**€1,317**	**€1,547**	**€1,818**	**€2,137**	**€2,510**	**€2,950**	**€3,466**	**€4,072**	**€4,785**	**€5,623**	**€32,300**	**€205,274**	**€997,386**
Enterprise Ireland Grant	€30,000	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	€30,000	-	-
Total Net Income	**€30,954**	**€1,121**	**€1,317**	**€1,547**	**€1,818**	**€2,137**	**€2,510**	**€2,950**	**€3,466**	**€4,072**	**€4,785**	**€5,623**	**€62,300**	**€205,274**	**€997,386**
OPERATING EXPENSES															
Salaries & Wages	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€36,000	€36,900	€175,000
Payroll Taxes	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€4,050	€4,151	€19,688
Advertising & Marketing	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€24,000	€48,000	€96,000
Research & Development	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€4,800	€4,920	€5,043
Rent / Storage	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€4,800	€4,920	€5,043
Transport / Courier	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€3,000	€13,063	€43,988
Accounting Fees	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€2,400	€2,460	€2,522
Technology costs	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€1,200	€1,230	€1,261
Professional / Legal Fees	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€1,500	€1,538	€1,576
Electricity & Gas	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€960	€984	€1,009
Sundries	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€792	€812	€832
Business Registration	€50	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	€50	€51	€53
Product Liability Insurance	€1,500	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	€1,500	€1,538	€1,576
Website Amortisation	€83	€83	€83	€83	€83	€83	€83	€83	€83	€83	€83	€83	€1,000	€1,000	€1,000
Total Operating Expenses	**€8,592**	**€7,042**	**€7,042**	**€7,042**	**€7,042**	**€7,042**	**€7,042**	**€7,042**	**€7,042**	**€7,042**	**€7,042**	**€7,042**	**€86,052**	**€121,566**	**€354,589**
RESULT															
Operating Profit / (Loss)	**€22,362**	**(€5,921)**	**(€5,725)**	**(€5,494)**	**(€5,224)**	**(€4,905)**	**(€4,531)**	**(€4,092)**	**(€3,576)**	**(€2,969)**	**(€2,257)**	**(€1,419)**	**(€23,752)**	**€83,708**	**€642,798**
Corporation Tax Payable (12.5%)	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	€10,463	€80,350
Net Profit / (Loss)	**€22,362**	**(€5,921)**	**(€5,725)**	**(€5,494)**	**(€5,224)**	**(€4,905)**	**(€4,531)**	**(€4,092)**	**(€3,576)**	**(€2,969)**	**(€2,257)**	**(€1,419)**	**(€23,752)**	**€73,244**	**€562,448**

MANTIS – BALANCE SHEET FORECAST

	Year 1 31-Dec-2027	Year 2 31-Dec-2028	Year 3 31-Dec-2029
ASSETS			
Current Assets			
Cash at Bank	€60,861	€96,031	€539,894
Accounts Receivable	€11,387	€60,925	€250,396
Total Current Assets	**€72,248**	**€156,956**	**€790,290**
Fixed Assets			
Equipment (net of depreciation)	€4,000	€3,000	€2,000
Total Non-Current Assets	**€4,000**	**€3,000**	**€2,000**
TOTAL ASSETS	**€76,248**	**€159,956**	**€792,290**
LIABILITIES			
Current Liabilities			
Corporation Tax Payable	-	€10,463	€80,350
Total Current Liabilities	**-**	**€10,463**	**€80,350**
Long-term Liabilities	-	-	-
Total Non-Current Liabilities	**-**	**-**	**-**
Total Liabilities	**-**	**€10,463**	**€80,350**
OWNER'S EQUITY			
Shareholder Equity	€100,000	€100,000	€100,000
Retained earnings	(€23,752)	€49,492	€611,940
Total Equity	**€76,248**	**€149,492**	**€711,940**
Total Liabilities & Equity	**€76,248**	**€159,956**	**€792,290**

MANTIS – CASH FLOW PROJECTIONS															
	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec	Year 1 Total	Year 2 Total	Year 3 Total
CASH INFLOWS															
Capital Injection	€100,000	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	€100,000	-	-
Enterprise Ireland Grant	€30,000	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	€30,000	-	-
Cash Receipts from Sales	€828	€2,905	€3,413	€4,011	€4,712	€5,537	€6,506	€7,645	€8,982	€10,554	€12,401	€14,572	€82,067	€493,020	€2,246,585
Total Cash Inflows	**€130,828**	**€2,905**	**€3,413**	**€4,011**	**€4,712**	**€5,537**	**€6,506**	**€7,645**	**€8,982**	**€10,554**	**€12,401**	**€14,572**	**€212,067**	**€493,020**	**€2,246,585**
CASH OUTFLOWS															
Cost of Goods Sold	€1,806	€2,122	€2,494	€2,930	€3,443	€4,045	€4,753	€5,585	€6,562	€7,710	€9,060	€10,645	€61,154	€337,285	€1,438,670
Salaries & Wages	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€36,000	€36,900	€175,000
Payroll Taxes	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€338	€4,050	€4,151	€19,688
Advertising & Marketing	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€2,000	€24,000	€48,000	€96,000
Research & Development	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€4,800	€4,920	€5,043
Rent / Storage	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€400	€4,800	€4,920	€5,043
Transport / Courier	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€250	€3,000	€13,063	€43,988
Accounting Fees	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€200	€2,400	€2,460	€2,522
Technology costs	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€100	€1,200	€1,230	€1,261
Professional / Legal Fees	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€125	€1,500	€1,538	€1,576
Electricity & Gas	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€80	€960	€984	€1,009
Sundries	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€66	€792	€812	€832
Business Registration	€50	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	€50	€51	€53
Product Liability Insurance	€1,500	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	€1,500	€1,538	€1,576
Website	€5,000	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	€5,000	-	-
Corporation Tax Paid	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	€10,463
Total Cash Outflows	**€15,315**	**€9,081**	**€9,452**	**€9,888**	**€10,401**	**€11,004**	**€11,711**	**€12,543**	**€13,521**	**€14,669**	**€16,018**	**€17,604**	**€151,206**	**€457,851**	**€1,802,722**
CASH POSITION															
Opening Balance	-	€115,513	€109,338	€103,299	€97,421	€91,732	€86,266	€81,061	€76,162	€71,624	€67,510	€63,893	-	€60,861	€96,031
Net Cash Movement	€115,513	(€6,176)	(€6,039)	(€5,878)	(€5,689)	(€5,466)	(€5,205)	(€4,899)	(€4,538)	(€4,114)	(€3,617)	(€3,032)	€60,861	€35,170	€443,863
Closing Balance	**€115,513**	**€109,338**	**€103,299**	**€97,421**	**€91,732**	**€86,266**	**€81,061**	**€76,162**	**€71,624**	**€67,510**	**€63,893**	**€60,861**	**€60,861**	**€96,031**	**€539,894**

Sensitivity Analysis

The following analysis models the impact of sales volume variance on key financial metrics across three projection years, and outlines the management actions that would be taken in each scenario. Fixed operating costs remain constant in all scenarios with the exception of transport, and variable COGS moves proportionally with volume sold. Three scenarios are presented against base case projections. The base case reflects current projections, a downside of 20% below target growth volume, a severe downside of 30% below target growth volume, and an upside of 20% above target growth volume. All the scenarios have a compounding effect on the monthly/annual growth volume targets.

Management Response

The gross profit margin is constant across all scenarios at 34.6% in Year 1, 37.8% in Year 2, and 40.9% in Year 3, as both price and cost per unit remain unchanged with volume. The net margin deteriorates in downside scenarios because fixed costs are spread across less revenue.

In the event of a 20% volume shortfall, Mantis would reduce the marketing budget by 50% to €12,000, shifting from paid digital advertising to organic social media and gym floor sampling. This action recovers approximately €16,800 in cash and is sufficient to maintain a positive cash position without any other structural changes. Retail expansion would be reprioritised toward gyms, which have a shorter sales cycle and lower buyer approval barriers than Holland & Barrett and Nourish, with those listings pushed to the third quarter.

In a Severe Downside of 30%, the above actions would be implemented alongside the deferral of founder salaries for three to six months, with the five founders taking drawings only as cash

allows. Mantis would also engage Enterprise Ireland to explore whether additional HPSU support or a repayable advance is available.

Key Finding

Even in the Severe Downside scenario, Mantis maintains a positive cash balance in Year 1 and Year 2. The only scenario producing a negative cash position is a sustained 30% volume shortfall carried through all three years without any management intervention. In practice, the management responses outlined above would be triggered well before Year 3, making this outcome avoidable. The starting capital of €100,000 from founders and the €30,000 Enterprise Ireland grant provides sufficient runway to absorb early-stage underperformance while the brand establishes itself in the Irish market.

Metric Year 1	Base Case	Downside –20%	Severe Downside –30%	Upside +20%
VOLUME & REVENUE				
Units Sold (Year 1)	35,045	28,225	25,361	43,617
Sales Revenue (€)	€93,454	€75,267	€67,628	€116,311
COST STRUCTURE				
Cost of Goods Sold (€)	€61,154	€49,253	€44,254	€76,111
Gross Profit (€)	€32,300	€26,014	€23,374	€40,200
Total Operating Expenses (€)	€86,052	€86,052	€86,052	€86,052
PROFITABILITY				
Operating / Net Profit (€)	(€23,752)	(€30,038)	(€32,678)	(€15,852)
Gross Profit Margin %	34.6%	34.6%	34.6%	34.6%
Net Profit Margin %	-25.4%	-28.5%	-33.5%	-10.8%
CASH POSITION				
Closing Cash Balance Y1 (€)	€60,861	€57,797	€56,435	€64,421

Metric Year 2	Base Case	Downside –20%	Severe Downside –30%	Upside +20%
VOLUME & REVENUE				
Units Sold (Year 2)	203,459	118,229	89,850	347,275
Sales Revenue (€)	€542,558	€315,278	€239,601	€926,066
COST STRUCTURE				
Cost of Goods Sold (€)	€337,285	€195,995	€148,949	€575,695
Gross Profit (€)	€205,274	€119,284	€90,651	€350,371
Total Operating Expenses (€)	€121,566	€117,928	€116,475	€126,418
PROFITABILITY				
Operating / Net Profit (€)	€83,708	€1,356	(€25,823)	€223,954
Gross Profit Margin %	37.8%	37.8%	37.8%	37.8%
Net Profit Margin %	13.5%	0.4%	-10.8%	21.2%
CASH POSITION				
Closing Cash Balance Y2 (€)	€96,031	€36,507	€15,674	€190,489

Metric Year 3	Base Case	Downside –20%	Severe Downside –30%	Upside +20%
VOLUME & REVENUE				
Units Sold (Year 3)	913,521	400,864	263,854	2,047,785
Sales Revenue (€)	€2,436,056	€1,068,971	€703,611	€5,460,760
COST STRUCTURE				
Cost of Goods Sold (€)	€1,438,670	€631,306	€415,534	€3,224,980
Gross Profit (€)	€997,386	€437,665	€288,077	€2,235,780
Total Operating Expenses (€)	€354,589	€334,567	€328,158	€389,829
PROFITABILITY				
Operating / Net Profit (€)	€642,798	€103,098	(€40,081)	€1,845,951
Gross Profit Margin %	40.9%	40.9%	40.9%	40.9%
Net Profit Margin %	23.1%	8.4%	-5.7%	29.6%
CASH POSITION				
Closing Cash Balance Y3 (€)	€539,894	€72,410	(€63,035)	€1,510,856

Sales Pipeline

Mantis will distribute exclusively through physical retail channels, targeting health and wellness stores, gyms, and fitness studios across Ireland. Our route to market is built around three channel types, Holland & Barrett, Nourish, and independent gyms and fitness studios nationwide, placing Mantis on over 780 shelves across the country.

Our core target consumer is the gym-going 18 to 34 year old. Ireland's population of approximately 5.1 million includes roughly 1.3 million adults in this age group (CSO, 2022), with 41% of 25 to 34 year olds already performing muscle-strengthening exercises (CSO, 2021), giving an addressable base of over 500,000 active young adults already engaged in strength and fitness training. The Irish Sports Monitor 2024 confirms that personal exercise and weight training are among the fastest-growing physical activities in the country (Sport Ireland, 2025), reinforcing the structural demand for convenient, high-performance protein products like Mantis.

Year 1 sales begin at 1,035 units in January 2027 and grow at 17.5% per month as brand awareness develops and repeat purchasing establishes. By December 2027, monthly volume reaches 6,100 units, closing the year at 35,045 units and €93,454 in wholesale revenue, representing less than one purchase per week from just over 1,300 consumers, or under 0.3% of the total addressable base. Year 2 reflects a full year of active listings across all three channels, with monthly growth moderating to 15% as the business transitions from launch into retail consolidation, reaching 203,459 units and €542,558 in revenue. Year 3 growth of 12.5% per month drives 913,521 units and €2,436,056 in revenue as Mantis establishes itself as a recognised brand within the Irish health and wellness market.

Over the three-year projection period, Mantis targets cumulative sales of 1,152,026 units and total wholesale revenue of €3,072,069. All revenue is generated at a fixed wholesale price of €2.67 per unit, producing a retail shelf price of €4.00 after the standard 50% retail markup.

MANTIS | SALES PIPELINE													
Year 1 | 2027													
Year 1	**Jan**	**Feb**	**Mar**	**Apr**	**May**	**Jun**	**Jul**	**Aug**	**Sep**	**Oct**	**Nov**	**Dec**	**Total**
Units Sold	1,035	1,216	1,429	1,679	1,973	2,318	2,724	3,200	3,760	4,419	5,192	6,100	**35,045**
Revenue (€)	€2,760	€3,243	€3,811	€4,477	€5,261	€6,182	€7,263	€8,534	€10,028	€11,783	€13,845	€16,268	**€93,454**
Year 2 | 2028													
Year 2	**Jan**	**Feb**	**Mar**	**Apr**	**May**	**Jun**	**Jul**	**Aug**	**Sep**	**Oct**	**Nov**	**Dec**	**Total**
Units Sold	7,015	8,068	9,278	10,670	12,270	14,111	16,227	18,661	21,460	24,679	28,381	32,639	**203,459**
Revenue (€)	€18,708	€21,514	€24,741	€28,452	€32,720	€37,628	€43,272	€49,763	€57,228	€65,812	€75,684	€87,036	**€542,558**
Year 3 | 2029													
Year 3	**Jan**	**Feb**	**Mar**	**Apr**	**May**	**Jun**	**Jul**	**Aug**	**Sep**	**Oct**	**Nov**	**Dec**	**Total**
Units Sold	36,718	41,308	46,472	52,281	58,816	66,168	74,439	83,744	94,211	105,988	119,236	134,141	**913,521**
Revenue (€)	€97,916	€110,155	€123,925	€139,415	€156,842	€176,447	€198,503	€223,316	€251,231	€282,634	€317,964	€357,709	**€2,436,056**
3-YEAR TOTALS													
Total Units (3 Years)													**1,152,026**
Total Revenue (3 Years)													**€3,072,069**

Funding Requirements

100k Investment from the Five Owners

The five founders of Mantis will each contribute an investment of €20,000 to provide the startup capital . This contribution of €20,000 will entitle each owner to 19% ownership. This contribution is necessary to provide initial investment that builds up the equity base of the business.

This personal investment by the founders not only provides immediate liquidity but also signals a profound commitment to external stakeholders, creating a foundation that is vital for future growth. By prioritising equity funding over high-interest debt, Mantis secures permanent capital without the burden of immediate repayments, allowing the team to reinvest all early profits back into scaling the brand. This strategy is particularly effective in the Irish ecosystem, where building a strong equity base is a prerequisite for attracting follow-on investment and long-term stability. As noted by Enterprise Ireland, equity funding allows a business to share the risks of development with investors who bring more than just cash, often providing the "smart capital" and strategic networks necessary to break into the protein market.

Enterprise Ireland Grant

Following on from the initial €100,000 investment, Mantis will apply for Enterprise Ireland's New Frontiers Programme. Mantis is eligible to participate in this programme and will receive a

€30,000 allowance grant. This funding will allow Mantis to create unique branding ideas, and allow for the creation of prototypes without the loss of equity stake.

The programme also offers valuable one-to-one mentoring sessions through the Enterprise Ireland Mentor Network, workshops, networking opportunities, and a community of support, thus aiding the development of business connections and creation of working relationships within the industry. This support will aid ongoing profitability and ultimately lower production costs for the business.

During Phase One of the programme, Enterprise Ireland will allow Mantis to identify our value proposition during an 8-10 week period. Phase Two is where we will receive the €30,000 allowance grant, alongside expert advice and guidance. Mantis will gain access to third-level research and development facilities, one-to-one mentoring and expert-led workshops. After completion of Phase Two, Mantis can progress to Phase Three where a further support package of €10,000 is made available, alongside additional mentoring and an introduction to government and private investing. Ultimately, the New Frontiers programme provides Mantis with the essential financial runway and technical infrastructure needed to transform our sustainable insect protein concept into a market-ready reality. (Enterprise Ireland, 2014).

100k Investment from the Dragon's

Mantis are asking for an €100,000 investment in exchange for 5% of the company. This values Mantis at €2,000,000. 80% of the investment will go towards localising production, whilst the remaining 20% will go towards the research and development of producing Irish grown oat milk, as a substitute for out UHT milk. Using one of the founder's land in County Meath, Mantis will localise production by creating a high tech protein hub. Here, Mantis will produce massive yields of buffalo worms in a very compact footprint. To culture the worms, Mantis will invest in well-ventilated, climate controlled containers kept at 25-30 degrees celsius and a humidity of 60-70%. The worms will thrive on a sterile substrate of wheat and oats grown on site. The worms are then cleaned, stored and dehydrated for our beverage. By moving production to our own land, Mantis aren't just cutting costs, but creating a sustainable Irish protein source, eliminating half of our imports. (Diapteron, 2023).

The remaining €20,000 will aid Mantis to research about producing oat milk in Ireland. Currently Ireland depends on imports of oat milk from the UK, Italy, Germany, Spain and even as far as Chile. This is a carbon nightmare. By learning how to produce our own oat milk, Mantis will eliminate thousands of food miles and create a circular economy. Oat milk will be used in our functional drink, and the remaining oats are used to feed the buffalo worms. By investing €100,000 in our move towards vertical integration, the dragons are enabling Mantis to create an Irish Supply Chain that slashes logistical costs through local production. The dragons are helping us to protect the environment by eliminating thousands of import miles, and providing

us with the infrastructure needed to scale our business into a high-margin market leader. (6Wresearch, 2025).

How is Mantis valued at €2,000,000?

There are a number of ways to value a company. We have considered 3 methods based on our financial projections over 3 years and focusing particularly on year 3. We have used revenue multiples, Price to Earnings and Price to Book Value. All 3 methods have a value of €2million or slightly higher. Given the rate of growth in our sales projections we have applied the conservative end of times multiples in each valuation methodology.

1. Revenue multiples

Common start ups especially in food and beverage are commonly valued at 1 -3 times annual revenue. We have looked at 3 times annual revenue in year 2 and 1 times annual revenue in year 3 due to the rapid aggressive growth in sales in year 3 and by combining the average valuation of both years gives a valuation of €2.0million (Year 2 €1.6m + Year 3 €2.4m = €2.0m).

Revenue multiples			
		Year2	Year3
Sales Revenue		€542,558	€2,436,056
Times		3	1
Valuation		€1,627,675	**€2,436,056**

2. Price to Earnings (or times earnings)

For profitable start ups in manufacturing companies often trade between 4-5 times EBITDA. This can increase to 6-10 times EBITDA for high-growth beverage companies.

We will go for a conservative lower times earning multiple of 4 times due predictability (uncertainty) with forecasted profits and growth in a start-up.

(Note: National Beverage P/E as of March 27, 2026 is 18 times, so the potential for increased valuation after a number of years of trading is significant).

This values the company over €2.3million based on year 3 earnings.

Price to Earnings (or times earnings)			
		Year2	Year3
EBITDA		€74,244	€573,911
Times		4	4
Valuation		€296,977	**€2,295,646**

3. Price to Book Value i.e. equity (or times book value)

Equity represents the net value of a company.

The multiple for high-growth start-ups is generally high ranging from 2-5 times depending on strength of the brand and intellectual property. Taking a conservative 2.5 times book value gives a valuation of €2.0million based on year 3 equity value.

Price to Book Value (equity) or Times book value			
		Year2	Year3
Equity		€149,492	€711,940
Times		2.5	2.5
Valuation		€399,890	**€1,980,725**

Appendices

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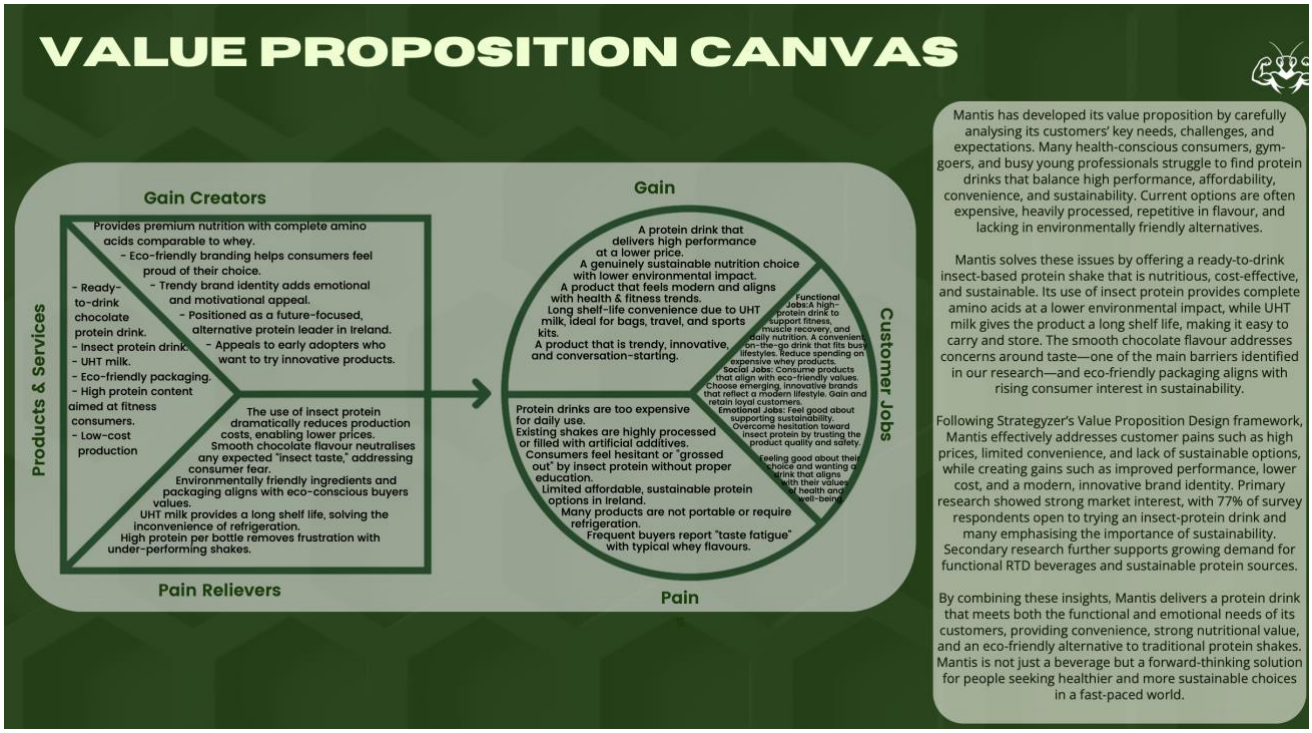

Mantis has developed its value proposition by carefully analysing its customers' key needs, challenges, and expectations. Many health-conscious consumers, gym-goers, and busy young professionals struggle to find protein drinks that balance high performance, affordability, convenience, and sustainability. Current options are often expensive, heavily processed, repetitive in flavour, and lacking in environmentally friendly alternatives.

Mantis solves these issues by offering a ready-to-drink insect-based protein shake that is nutritious, cost-effective, and sustainable. Its use of insect protein provides complete amino acids at a lower environmental impact, while UHT milk gives the product a long shelf life, making it easy to carry and store. The smooth chocolate flavour addresses concerns around taste—one of the main barriers identified in our research—and eco-friendly packaging aligns with rising consumer interest in sustainability.

Following Strategyzer's Value Proposition Design framework, Mantis effectively addresses customer pains such as high prices, limited convenience, and lack of sustainable options, while creating gains such as improved performance, lower cost, and a modern, innovative brand identity. Primary research showed strong market interest, with 77% of survey respondents open to trying an insect-protein drink and many emphasising the importance of sustainability. Secondary research further supports growing demand for functional RTD beverages and sustainable protein sources.

By combining these insights, Mantis delivers a protein drink that meets both the functional and emotional needs of its customers, providing convenience, strong nutritional value, and an eco-friendly alternative to traditional protein shakes. Mantis is not just a beverage but a forward-thinking solution for people seeking healthier and more sustainable choices in a fast-paced world.

BUSINESS MODEL CANVAS

Our Business Model Canvas outlines Mantis' business concept and how we plan to generate revenue. Creating this canvas has been essential for us as a start-up, helping us clearly visualise our strategy, understand our key activities and resources, and make informed decisions to improve our business moving forward.

Key Partners

- Insect protein suppliers
- UHT milk manufacturers
- Packaging suppliers
- Food scientists and product formulation experts
- Retail partners
- Fitness influencers

Key Activities

- Formulation & Testing
- Manufacturing
- Marketing
- Distribution
- Research & Improvement
- Sustainability Compliance

Key Resources

- Brand identity
- Insect protein formula
- UHT milk and packaging inventory
- Manufacturing facilities
- Digital presence
- Financial resources & team expertise

Value Proposition

- High-protein sustainable shake
- Lower production cost
- Complete nutrition comparable to whey
- Long shelf life, portable, convenient
- Smooth chocolate flavour
- Eco-friendly positioning

Channels

- Retail stores
- Fitness expos and sports events
- Influencer marketing
- Word of mouth
- Public Relations

Customer Relationships

- Community-driven social media
- Transparent education about insect protein
- Customer feedback loops

Customer Segments

- Health & fitness enthusiasts
- Eco-conscious consumers
- Students & young professionals
- Travellers/busy workers wanting convenience
- Early adopters interested in new protein sources

Cost Structure

- Production costs
- Marketing costs
- General admin costs
- Licensing costs

Revenue Stream

- Per unit retail sales

Primary Research Analysis

1. Awareness and Attitudes Toward Sustainability

A large proportion of respondents rated sustainability as important in their food and drink choices:

- 81 out of 157 (51.6%) selected "Very important" or "Important"
- Only 18 out of 157 (11.5%) said sustainability was "Not important"

This suggests that more than half of the potential market considers sustainability a meaningful factor, which aligns strongly with Mantis' positioning as an environmentally friendly protein drink.

2. Consumption of Protein Products

Protein drinks are already widely consumed among participants:

- 64 respondents (40.7%) consume protein shakes a few times per week
- 26 respondents (16.6%) consume them daily

Only 23 respondents (14.6%) said they never consume protein drinks

This shows a high level of familiarity with protein beverages, meaning Mantis is entering an already active consumer market with strong demand.

3. Openness to Insect Protein

A key measure of feasibility is whether consumers would try an insect-protein drink:

- 121 out of 157 respondents (77%) said they
  - "Definitely would try",
  - "Maybe would try", or
  - "Are unsure but open to it"
  - Only 36 respondents (23%) said they probably or definitely would not try it.

This means 3 out of 4 consumers are open to at least trying Mantis, provided their concerns are addressed.

4. Barriers to Trying an Insect-Protein Drink

When asked what would make them hesitant, respondents could select multiple barriers. The most common concerns were:

- Taste concerns – Appeared across the majority of responses
- Texture concerns – Frequently mentioned
- "The idea of insects" – One of the top concerns
- Lack of information – A common barrier
- Social stigma – Frequently mentioned in open responses

5. Price Sensitivity

When asked what price they would consider reasonable for a 500ml protein drink:

- The most selected range was €3–€4
- A significant portion also accepted €2–€3, making that the second most popular price range

Very few were willing to pay above €5

This aligns with mainstream Irish protein drink prices (e.g., GetPro, Avonmore Protein Milk), meaning Mantis can be priced competitively within consumer expectations.

6. Gaps in the Current Protein Drink Market

Open-ended responses revealed common consumer frustrations:

- Many mentioned overly artificial flavours
- Others said current drinks are too expensive
- Some noted high sugar content or overly processed ingredients

A notable number mentioned wanting more sustainable or natural options

This aligns strongly with Mantis' value proposition, which focuses on:

- A cleaner, more natural protein source
- Lower environmental impact
- Competitive pricing
- Long shelf-life convenience